

always has the latest copy of the repository, without having to demand it from the server, as in the former two cases. That last bit is purely academic, unless your needs have something in common with those of the Linux kernel, whose developers use a distributed version control software called GIT.

Getting Down To It

There is an embarrassment of choices when it comes to version control software, most of them open source. You can Google for the lot, but when it comes to it, the best option is Subversion, which is now the version control software of choice for nearly all open source software developers today—the older CVS (Concurrent Versioning System) has started to show its age, and Subversion goes well beyond it in terms of the features and flexibility it offers.

Subversion is most comfortable running as an Apache module on a Linux server. It can also run as a separate Linux daemon, and if you have a Windows server, you can set it to run as a service. Once you've set up a repository, there are a lot of ways to access it. When it's running as an Apache module, you can access your Subversion repository using the WebDAV (Web Distributed Authoring and Versioning) protocol—you can set it up in just a few clicks in Windows in My Network Places. Just add a new Network Place, put in the HTTP address of the Subversion repository, and it behaves like a regular folder!

If you choose not to use the Apache module, or if your server is running Windows, you can run "svnserve"—the Subversion server—which uses its own protocol for access to the repository. Naturally, you'll need software that uses this protocol on every machine that will access the repository.

Enter The Tortoise

TortoiseSVN is another open source project by the same organisation that develops Subversion, and is the recommended Subversion client for Windows PCs. Don't expect to see a program window or the like: it's just a shell extension that brings all your repository functions—check out, check in, and so forth—right to your Windows Explorer. Files under version control have their own icon overlays—a green check-mark to indicate that it's the latest version from the repository, a red exclamation to indicate



TortoiseSVN integrates all your repository functions with Windows Explorer

that you've changed the file but haven't sent it to the repository, and so on.

It takes a while to get used to TortoiseSVN, so you'll need to invest some time in training your employees. Once that's out of the way, though, the convenience of working in good old Windows Explorer is unparalleled.

Reality Check

Like everything else we recommend, do take some time out to analyse your situation before you take the plunge. The most important matter you need to address is whether there are enough "incidences" in your office to warrant the time and effort you need to invest in setting up Subversion—it isn't as easy a process as one would hope. Add to that the effort of training everyone to use the system.

You'll also have to take a good long look at the way your data is organised. The idea is the same that we used for the user groups in *Mayhem Management* last month—make a top level folder structure that represents each of your departments. Once that's done, try to divide everything into little "projects"—April 2006 Sales can be a project for your sales department, and this will contain all the files relevant to said month's figures.

After all this, if you decide to go ahead and incorporate Subversion at your office, do write in and tell us about your experiences! ■

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